

The Thinking Behind

Casteel Financial

Brand Strategy Notes for Our Marketing Consultant

Not a brand book. A record of the thinking behind one.

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PART ONE — THE BRAND

Why This Document Exists

This isn't a traditional brand book. It isn't a collection of slogans, logos, colors, or marketing ideas. It's an attempt to document the thinking behind Casteel Financial — the answers we've arrived at, and why, so future decisions (yours and ours) can be made consistently.

It grew out of an extended, conversational reflection process over several days — not a formal branding exercise with a facilitator and a whiteboard. That matters for how you should read it: some of it is settled conviction, some of it is still being worked out in real time. Part Two of this document is candid about which is which.

The questions that turned out to matter most weren't about logos or colors. They were about identity:

- Who are we?
- Who do we serve?
- What do clients actually value?
- Why do clients choose us?
- What kind of firm are we trying to build?
- How should clients feel after working with us?

The rest of this document captures our current answers.

Our Mission

We help people who built what they have through hard work navigate important financial decisions with confidence.

This sentence came up again and again across every conversation, because it captures the major themes of the firm: hard work, responsibility, decision-making, confidence, guidance. At its core, the mission isn't about investments, products, or reports — it's about helping people make thoughtful decisions and move forward with confidence.

Our Vision

To become the most trusted regional boutique financial planning firm serving hardworking families throughout Pennsylvania, West Virginia, Ohio, and eventually beyond.

We're not trying to become the largest firm, and we're not trying to become a national brand. We aspire to be a firm that consistently delivers excellent advice and exceptional client care. Growth matters. Trust matters more.

The Big Realizations

A handful of ideas kept resurfacing throughout these conversations. Together, they form the backbone of how we think about the business — and each one is paired with an “Instead of” statement, a habit that turned out to be one of the most useful tools for forcing real clarity: it defines what we are by being explicit about what we are not.

Most People Don't Want a Financial Plan

That sounds strange coming from a financial planner, but it's true. People don't wake up thinking, "I hope someone gives me a financial plan." They think: "Can I retire?" "Am I okay?" "What should I do next?" "How do I take care of my family?" The plan is rarely the goal — it's simply a tool.

Instead of: selling plans,
we help people find answers.

We're in the Confidence Business

We're not really in the investment business, and we're not really in the planning business. We're in the confidence business. Investments matter. Tax planning matters. Estate planning matters. Retirement planning matters. But those are tools — the outcome we're actually selling is confidence: **understanding where you stand, what comes next, and how to move forward.**

Instead of: creating reports,
we create confidence.

One story that captures this well: a retired teacher and her husband, a retired carpenter, came in having done almost everything right — worked hard, saved consistently, avoided major mistakes — yet they were still anxious. The most valuable thing we gave them wasn't an investment recommendation. It was **clarity**. They left relieved, not because anything changed, but because they finally understood their own situation. People rarely come looking for plans. They come looking for answers.

Most Client Problems Aren't Investment Problems

Many of the most meaningful conversations we have involve retirement decisions, taxes, estate planning, family dynamics, business transitions, and legacy planning — not portfolio construction. Most people don't need a better mutual fund. They need help making better decisions.

Instead of: focusing solely on investments,
we focus on helping clients make good financial decisions.

Who We Serve

For a long time, we tried to figure out whether the firm should focus on a specific niche — energy workers, royalty owners, retirees, business owners. Over time we realized those categories described a

lot of our clients but didn't fully define who we are. Our clients look very different on paper: a teacher, a business owner, a retiree, a farmer, a royalty owner, a tradesman, a professional. What unites them isn't occupation. It's character. They value hard work, family, responsibility, trust, community, and practical advice.

Instead of: serving a profession,
we serve people approaching important financial decisions.

Our Ideal Client

Our ideal client typically:

- Values trust and relationships
- Wants thoughtful guidance
- Appreciates expertise
- Does not want unnecessary complexity
- Believes in hard work and responsibility
- Wants help making important financial decisions

Many are:

- Age 50+
- Approaching retirement or recently retired
- Business owners
- Royalty owners
- Landowners
- Lifetime savers

Age and occupation are secondary, though. The defining trait is that they're approaching an important financial decision.

Where We Do Our Best Work

We're glad to help people at any stage of life, but our deepest expertise shows up when clients are navigating a real transition:

- Retirement
- Pension and Social Security elections
- Widowhood
- Estate planning and inheritances
- Business transitions
- Property transfers

- Tax planning opportunities
- Charitable planning

Hard Work Matters

Hard work shows up constantly in how we talk about the firm — not because we're building a blue-collar brand or an Appalachian brand, but because it reflects a deeper value: respect. Many of our clients spent decades showing up, working long hours, saving consistently, and taking care of their families. That wealth didn't happen overnight. It deserves respect.

Instead of: focusing on the wealth,
we focus on what it took to build it.

Positioning: How Narrow Should the Niche Be?

A Broad Identity, With a Narrow Content Engine Underneath

Lead the public brand with the identity-based positioning above — "people who built what they have through hard work" — rather than an occupation-based niche. Reasons:

- It's durable. Occupational niches (energy workers, royalty owners) describe a real concentration in the client base, but they're narrower than the actual firm — a teacher, a farmer, and a business owner all fit the identity-based story equally well.
- It matches the market. Waynesburg and the surrounding region isn't a large enough or specialized enough market to sustain a pure occupation-based niche the way a national virtual advisor serving physicians or pilots could. The real local advantage is **community trust** and comprehensive planning, not vertical specialization.
- It still lets you niche where it counts: content. Use "royalty owners," "farm succession," "business transition," and "energy industry retirement" as topics for articles, workshops, and referral-partner conversations — the specific, searchable, shareable material that actually drives referrals and SEO — while the brand itself stays broad enough to keep growing beyond any one group.

In short: **the identity is the brand; the occupations are the content strategy underneath it.**

The Alternative Josh Also Explored

A more concentrated version of the brand built explicitly around energy-industry and royalty-owner households, farm and land succession, and business owners preparing to sell or transition — leaning into deep, visible expertise in a small number of high-value, underserved problems (e.g., "What happens to mineral rights when you die?" or "Should gas royalties go into a trust?"). This could build faster authority and easier referrals within those specific communities, at the cost of a narrower story for clients who don't fit any of those buckets.

Worth discussing directly with Josh: how much of the current client base actually falls into these specific groups, and whether the firm wants its public identity to be led by them.

Geographic Positioning: Local Roots, Regional Reach

The question we kept coming back to: how local should the brand be? Positioned too narrowly (a "Greene County firm" or a "Waynesburg firm"), the brand risks feeling irrelevant to a royalty owner in Morgantown or a business owner in Wheeling, and it constrains future expansion into Pennsylvania, West Virginia, and Ohio. Positioned too generically, it starts to resemble every other regional wealth-management brand, loses its personal story, and its competitive advantage dissolves.

The resolution we landed on:

Story = Local. Market = Regional.

The firm's story stays deeply rooted in Southwestern Pennsylvania — family ties to ironworking, coal mining, and the early gas industry; a long-standing office in Waynesburg; real commitment to the region. Those details create credibility and trust. But the target market and the brand promise are built around a type of person, not a ZIP code, so the same message resonates just as well in Washington County, Morgantown, Wheeling, Charleston, or eastern Ohio.

Instead of: serving a geography,
we serve a type of person.

A Simple Brand Architecture

- Level 1 — Core identity: Families who built their wealth through hard work, land ownership, business ownership, and decades of saving.
- Level 2 — Technical expertise: Retirement transitions, energy and royalty households, tax planning, estate planning, business succession.
- Level 3 — Local story: Southwestern Pennsylvania, energy communities, working families, deep regional roots.

Website Implication

Avoid leading the homepage with "Serving Greene County Since..." Lead with the identity ("Hard Work Deserves a Plan." or similar), and let the location become supporting proof of authenticity further down the page, not the entire value proposition.

What Makes Us Different

Most advisory firms lead with investments. Investments matter, but they're rarely the most important conversation a client has with us. Many of our most meaningful conversations involve family, taxes, retirement, estate planning, legacy, and decision-making generally.

Instead of: asking "How can we build a better portfolio?"
we ask "What decision deserves our attention right now?"

What We Are Not

- A Wall Street firm
- A product-driven sales organization
- A transaction-based business
- A luxury wealth-management brand
- A performance-chasing firm

Instead of: trying to look bigger,
we strive to be trustworthy.

Instead of: trying to impress people,
we try to help them.

Instead of: selling products,
we solve problems.

Brand Voice

We sound: thoughtful, calm, genuine, direct, helpful.

We do not sound: corporate, aggressive, flashy, overly technical.

Instead of: speaking like financial experts,
we speak like trusted guides.

Our Brand Promise: Personal. Proactive. Practical.

Personal

We seek to understand the person before the portfolio.

Proactive

We identify opportunities and risks before they become urgent.

Practical

We explain things clearly and focus on advice that can actually be implemented — not flashy, not complicated, not theoretical. Useful.

These three words should be a filter for every future decision — marketing, hiring, technology, service design, client experience. If something isn't Personal, Proactive, or Practical, it probably doesn't belong.

Financial Craftsmanship

One of the ideas that best defines the firm. The people we serve understand craftsmanship — the difference between doing something quickly and doing something correctly. Good craftsmen pay attention to detail, stand behind their work, and refuse to cut corners. We believe financial advice should work the same way: thorough preparation, careful analysis, thoughtful recommendations, clear communication, consistent follow-through.

Internally, we describe this as "looking under every rock in the creek" — not because every rock hides a problem, but because every client deserves to know someone looked.

Instead of: checking boxes,
we look under every rock.

Trust and the County Fair Test

Trust is the single most important word in this document. Many clients carry stories about an advisor who sold a product, completed a transaction, and disappeared — and those stories shape how people see our profession. We build trust through small, consistent actions: returning calls, following through, keeping promises, telling the truth, being present when life gets difficult.

Instead of: earning a sale,
we seek to earn trust.

The County Fair Test

The simplest expression of our culture: if we run into a client at the county fair, at church, at the grocery store, or at a football game, we want them to be genuinely happy to see us — not because of investment performance, but because they trust us and know we care.

Instead of: measuring success by assets,
we measure success by trust.

Community and Education

Community isn't a marketing strategy — it's part of who we are. We care about building a community where future generations want to live, work, raise families, and contribute, which is why we value service, leadership, education, and civic involvement.

Instead of: asking what we can take from a community,
we ask how we can contribute to it.

Education is one of the firm's biggest opportunities. Many of the most meaningful client conversations aren't really about money — they're about understanding, clearing up misconceptions, reducing fear, and explaining complex topics simply.

Instead of: showing how much we know,
we focus on helping people understand.

What We Believe About Money

A few plain-language commitments that surfaced repeatedly and could anchor client-facing "how we help" messaging:

- We help families **keep more of what they've earned** and give less to the government than they otherwise would.
- We help clients intentionally pass assets and **legacies** on to future generations, rather than leaving it to chance.
- Client money is invested in a way designed to grow it — and, just as importantly, designed so clients don't run out.
- Client cash flow is **intentionally structured** to **support** what they actually want to do in life, not just to accumulate.

What Clients Actually Thank Us For

Clients rarely thank us for asset allocation, portfolio construction, or rebalancing. They thank us for:

- Reassurance — helping them understand they're going to be okay.
- Clarity — helping them understand something complicated.
- Confidence — helping them know what to do next.
- Stability — helping them navigate a difficult transition.

Instead of: leaving with more information,
clients leave with more confidence.

Tagline and Brand Essence

STATUS: LEADING CANDIDATES, NOT FINAL

These are the strongest options that emerged, and Josh wants your read on them — not a locked decision. Treat them as a starting point for testing and refinement, not a brief to execute as-is.

Leading Tagline

"Hard Work Deserves a Plan."

The strongest option so far because it honors the client's journey rather than describing our service. The deeper meaning isn't that people need a written plan — it's that after a lifetime of hard work, important decisions deserve thoughtful guidance.

Leading Brand Essence

"Trustworthy Financial Craftsmanship."

One-Sentence Positioning Statement

We help people who built what they have through hard work navigate important financial decisions with confidence.

Supporting Messaging Lines

- "Helping People Make Good Financial Decisions" — a simple description of what we do.
- "Financial Craftsmanship" — a description of how we do it.
- "Personal. Proactive. Practical." — how clients experience the relationship.
- "Local Roots. Regional Reach." — our growth strategy.

Content and Marketing Ideas Already on the Table

None of this is required reading for the brand itself, but it reflects real thinking Josh has already done about how the brand shows up in marketing — useful raw material rather than a finished plan.

A Simple Growth Flywheel

Content → Trust → Meetings → Plans → Relationships → Referrals → More Content.

Article and Workshop Topics Already Brainstormed

- What happens to mineral rights when you die?
- Should gas royalties go into a trust?

- How much cash should retirees keep at the bank?
- Common mistakes after receiving royalty income
- How to pass land to children fairly
- What every business owner should know before retiring
- The retirement mistakes hardworking people make
- You've spent your whole life working — don't make these retirement mistakes
- Three ways landowners accidentally create problems for their kids

Possible Educational Events

- Planning for Royalty Owners
- What Happens to the Family Farm?
- Preparing to Sell a Business
- Estate Planning for Landowners
- Keeping More of What You've Earned

Referral Relationships Worth Building Deliberately

- CPAs
- Attorneys
- Bankers
- Key business owners
- Royalty owners / landmen

The suggested approach with each: ask them directly about the common challenges their clients face and how a financial planner could help — relationship-building, not a pitch.

Long-Term Vision

We're building a trusted regional boutique — a firm known for **trust, craftsmanship, thoughtful advice, and genuinely caring for clients**. A firm that eventually grows beyond its founder, develops future advisors, and survives long after Josh is gone.

How We Hope to Be Remembered

- We worked hard for them.
- We cared.
- We asked questions others missed.
- We explained things clearly.
- We looked under every rock in the creek.

- We helped them make important decisions.
- We treated their families with respect and dignity.

The Single Most Important Idea

If this entire document had to be reduced to one paragraph:

ULTIMATE BRAND STATEMENT

Casteel Financial helps people who built what they have through hard work navigate important financial decisions with **confidence**. Through thoughtful planning, financial **craftsmanship**, and trusted relationships, we help clients gain **clarity**, reduce uncertainty, and focus more of their energy on the people and experiences that matter most.

PART TWO — BEHIND THE SCENES

This part is for you, not for a client or a website. It's the candid context behind Part One — how it came together, what's genuinely still undecided, and where we'd value your judgment most.

How This Document Came Together

Part One is a synthesis of an extended, self-directed reflection process — late nights, a long drive, and a lot of wrestling with advisor-industry podcasts and articles about niches and positioning. It was not produced through a formal branding workshop, a facilitator, or client research. That means the ideas are genuinely Josh's and are grounded in his real experience running the firm, but they haven't yet been pressure-tested against client interviews, competitor research, or message testing — all things a professional process like yours is well-suited to do next.

Treat everything in Part One as a strong, thought-through starting point — not a finished brief. Push back on anything that doesn't hold up.

The Name and Timeline

CONFIRMED

The future name is Casteel Financial, with a target effective date of January 1, 2027. Earlier drafts of this thinking referenced other names (e.g., "Casteel Wealth Management") and other target dates — those were explored and superseded. Casteel Financial / January 1, 2027 is the version to build from.

???????? - Casteel Financial or Casteel Wealth Management or Casteel Asset Management

Worth double-checking before anything goes out under the new name: Form ADV Part 1 (Item 1.C) and Form CRS both need to be amended promptly once the change is legally effective, not on the normal annual cycle — and client-facing materials during any transition window should probably reference both names together rather than switching overnight.

The Niche Question — Genuinely Open

When asked directly, Josh said he's "a little mixed" on this and wanted a recommendation rather than just a summary — which is exactly what Part One gives you (broad identity brand, narrow content engine underneath). But don't read that as Josh being fully sold on it. This is the one strategic question in the whole document where his own conviction is still forming, and where your outside perspective — especially anything you learn from reviewing his actual client base — could genuinely change the final direction.

A useful diagnostic exercise for your kickoff: pull Josh's top clients by revenue and by how much he enjoys working with them, and look for real concentration by industry or life situation (energy/gas, agriculture, business ownership, etc.). If a strong pattern exists, it may be worth leaning further into a named niche than Part One currently recommends.

The Tagline and Brand Essence — Not Locked

"Hard Work Deserves a Plan." and "Trustworthy Financial Craftsmanship" are presented in Part One as leading candidates because they're genuinely the strongest options that emerged — but Josh was explicit that he wants these treated as open, not final. Please bring your own read on both, including how "Hard Work Deserves a Plan" might land with clients who wouldn't describe their own life as blue-collar or "hard work" in the physical-labor sense (e.g., professionals, business owners who inherited or built differently).

What's Intentionally Left Out of This Document

At Josh's request, this document stays brand-only. It deliberately does not cover the firm's client-tier / service-segmentation strategy (the internal structure behind who gets what level of service, and how that maps to public marketing). That's real, already-developed strategy that will eventually intersect with your work — particularly around what the website emphasizes as the flagship offering — but Josh wants to hand it to you separately and on his own terms, not bundled into the brand-thinking document. Flag to Josh directly if you find you need that context to do the positioning or website work well.

Still Undecided / Not Yet Built (a "Version 3.0" list)

- Visual identity: no logo, color palette, or typography has been discussed at all — this document is entirely about voice and positioning, not visual design.
- Founder story: Josh's personal history (family background, why he bought the firm, early career) hasn't been captured yet, but is considered one of the biggest remaining opportunities for authentic differentiation.
- A client story library: anonymized, lesson-focused client stories (like the teacher/carpenter story in Part One) should be collected on an ongoing basis — none exist yet beyond the one or two captured here.
- A founder letter: intentionally deferred until the firm has operated under the Casteel name for a while, so it can speak to real experience rather than aspiration.

Suggested Next Step

Josh's own instinct — and a reasonable one — is to share this document, gather reactions from you and a couple of trusted people, and ask simply: "After reading this, what stands out?" From there, the natural follow-on conversations are pricing, capacity, service tiers, staffing, and growth — which may end up feeding back into the brand itself, so it's worth planning a second working session once those are further along.

We have a lot of Cs in this document. Maybe we could do something with that?

Casteel – Clarity, Confidence, Commitment, Connection, Craftsmanship

Alex Hormozi one liner - "A lot of people are broke and I don't want you to be one of them"